

requirements of the product owner (the manager of the process—in this case Farb—who is responsible for prioritizing the stories).

How did the team feel at the end of each sprint? They consistently delivered new product features. They would collect feedback from customers in the form of anecdotes and interviews that indicated that at least some customers liked the new features. There was always a certain amount of data that showed improvement: perhaps the total number of customers was increasing, the total number of questions answered by students was going up, or the number of returning customers was increasing.

However, I sensed that Farb and his team were left with lingering doubts about the company's overall progress. Was the increase in their numbers actually caused by their development efforts? Or could it be due to other factors, such as mentions of Grockit in the press? When I met the team, I asked them this simple question: How do you know that the prioritization decisions that Farb is making actually make sense?

Their answer: "That's not our department. Farb makes the decisions; we execute them."

At that time Grockit was focused on just one customer segment: prospective business school students who were studying for the GMAT. The product allowed students to engage in online study sessions with fellow students who were studying for the same exam. The product was working: the students who completed their studying via Grockit achieved significantly higher scores than they had before. But the Grockit team was struggling with the age-old startup problems: How do we know which features to prioritize? How can we get more customers to sign up and pay? How can we get out the word about our product?

I put this question to Farb: "How confident are you that you are making the right decisions in terms of establishing priorities?" Like most startup founders, he was looking at the available data and making the best educated guesses he could. But this left a lot of room for ambiguity and doubt.

Farb believed in his vision thoroughly and completely, yet he was starting to question whether his company was on pace to realize